THE "EYEBALL TO EYEBALL" METAPHOR BECAME THE FOUNDING myth of the historiography of the Cuban missile crisis. The dramatic moment in which Kennedy, speaking at the morning meeting of ExCom on October 24, gave the order to go after the Soviet vessels, which Robert Kennedy so amply described in his memoir, was indeed every bit as dramatic and potentially dangerous as it emerges from the book. It was also the moment that encapsulated everything Kennedy was afraid of as he kept coming back to Barbara Tuchman's book and thinking about the danger of misinformation and misunderstanding. Being misled by outdated and incomplete intelligence, he gave the order to attack ships that unbeknownst to him had already changed course and turned back from Cuba more than twenty-four hours earlier.

Neither Kennedy nor the members of the ExCom had access to the latest information supplied by Navy surveillance planes. It took hours for that information to get to the White House, forcing the president and his aides to make their decisions in virtual darkness. When McNamara first mentioned the dry cargo ship *Kimovsk* in the ExCom discussion on October 23, it was already on its way back to the Soviet Union. At 3:00 a.m. on October 23 the *Kimovsk* was spotted 300 miles east of the future quarantine line drawn 500 nautical miles from the eastern tip of Cuba. By 10:00 a.m. on October 24 the ship had traveled hundreds of miles farther east. The location of the *Kimovsk*, coupled with intercepted communication to the effect that it was heading toward the Baltic Sea, suggested that it was on its way home, not executing a maneuver to deceive the Americans and return to Cuba from a different direction.[21]

The *Gagarin* was going back as well, heading not for Odesa or the Black Sea but for Baltiisk on the Baltic Sea. Its thirty-seven-year-old captain, Kim Holubenko, had been ordered to turn back at 8:30 a.m. on October 23. Holubenko complied immediately. The *Gagarin* was already headed back east when, soon after 6:00 p.m. on October 23, a four-engine American plane dropped two explosives in front of the ship after flying over it three times with the plane's searchlights turned on. Shortly afterward, at 7:01 p.m., another American plane showed up. With searchlights on, it overflew the *Gagarin* six times. At 7:40 p.m., a third plane flew over the ship a mere 70 meters above its mast. Between 8:43 and